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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

‘Small’ security force set for Minn.

Border czar says guards will protect federal agents in Twin Cities; mass deportations to continue

By Ben Finley
Associated Press

WASHINGTON — White House border czar Tom Homan said Sunday that more than 1,000 immigration agents have left Minnesota’s Twin Cities area and

hundreds more will depart in the days ahead as part of the Trump administration’s drawdown of its immigration enforcement surge.

A “small” security force will stay for a short period to protect remaining immigration agents and will respond “when our agents

are out and they get surrounded by agitators and things got out of control,” Homan told CBS’ “Face the Nation.” He did not define “small.”

Homan said enforcement would not stop in the Twin Cities and that mass deportations will continue across the country. Officers leaving Minnesota will report back to their stations or be assigned elsewhere.

He also said agents will keep investigating fraud allegations as well as the anti-immigration enforcement protest that disrupted a service at a church service.

“We already removed well over 1,000 people, and as of Monday, Tuesday, we’ll remove several hundred more,” Homan said. “We’ll get back to the original footprint.”

Thousands of officers were sent to the Minneapolis and St. Paul

area for U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement’s “Operation Metro Surge.”

The Department of Homeland Security said it was its largest immigration enforcement operation ever and proved successful. But the crackdown came under increasing criticism as the situation grew more volatile and two

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Rodney Westerfield, left, and a team of workers tear up water-damaged hardwood floors from a 2000 renovation in the gym before they are replaced at the historic YMCA building in Chicago on Feb. 5. The Harlem Globetrotters trained regularly in the YMCA’s gym. **BRIAN CASSELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

‘You need to remind them’

Black History Month is 100.
Can its Bronzeville birthplace
outlast the age of Trump?

By Christopher Borrelli | Chicago Tribune

The history of Black History Month began 100 years ago, in the old YMCA building on South Wabash, a wide-shouldered block of pale red brick erected in 1913. It was once the nexus of Bronzeville, the premier gathering spot. At least 80 Chicago organizations met there regularly. When the Harlem Globetrotters (which formed in Bronzeville) were still a novelty, they trained regularly in its gym, for years. If you moved to Chicago during the Great Migration and didn’t have a place to stay, you stayed here, maybe. If you were lucky. During the peak of the Great Migration, the YMCA turned away 20 travelers a day.

The people who work there now, the small staff of the Renaissance Collaborative — which bought the building in 1992, rescuing it from demolition — don’t assume you know any of that. They figure Chicagoans do not know Black History Month took shape here.

When program manager Tara Balcerzak began fundraising for the building’s latest renovation, she told the group’s founder, Patricia Abrams, that she would lean into its role in the creation of Black History Month. Abrams said everyone already knew that; she’d told that story herself for years, while she raising \$11 million for the first restoration of the Y.

They’ve since learned people forget, said Fara Taylor, director of finance.

She smiled sadly. “You need to remind them, remind them once more — then again.”

Except, here’s the irony about having to remind them: Considering the political climate, is it possible to draw too much attention to the old YMCA and its history? Balcerzak wonders

that. Of course, they do need the attention, she said; she just worries what it could mean in 2026. Even this newspaper story worries her.

“Yes,” she said, “I feel an urgency to see the restoration through, as soon as possible.” See, a few years ago, to renovate this birthplace of Black History Month, they landed a \$436,375 grant from the Historic Preservation Fund, which is administered by the National Park Service. That was before federal agencies started removing Black history from websites, erasing names of Black soldiers from battle- ships and deciding not to recognize Black History Month.

On a recent Monday afternoon, Balcerzak and Taylor stood outside the building’s indoor swimming pool, which is drained and gray and been waiting a decade for its renovation.

Balcerzak chose her words carefully: “There haven’t been any threats.”

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City treasurer employee files ethics complaint

Portfolio manager alleges political staff pushed office on plan to boycott US bonds

By Alice Yin
Chicago Tribune

A whistleblower in City Treasurer Melissa Conyears-Ervin’s office filed a wide-ranging ethics complaint against her late last year, alleging the congressional candidate’s political staff pushed a questionable plan to boycott U.S. Treasury bonds in protest of President Donald Trump, despite

internal objections over its financial prudence.

Mauricio Banuelos, a treasurer’s office portfolio manager, sent an eight-page complaint to the public integrity units of both the Illinois attorney general and U.S. Department of Justice in November, pointing to conduct that “may jeopardize public funds or undermine the integrity of government operations,” according to a copy of the document obtained by the Tribune.

Conyears-Ervin’s announcement to not buy U.S. Treasuries has not led to any material changes so far because the city does not have any in its portfolio,



Chicago Treasurer Melissa Conyears-Ervin is the subject of an employee’s ethics complaint. **STACEY WESCOTT/TRIBUNE**

making her anti-Trump stance largely symbolic. Banuelos alleges interference from her political campaign shows the proposal

was “messaging, not a legitimate investment-policy action.”

His complaint says his “duties place me in a unique position to observe conduct within the Treasurer’s Office that implicates federal, state, and municipal laws, including potential misuse of office for campaign purposes, political influence over fiduciary matters, and retaliation for protected compliance activity.”

Banuelos declined to comment. Illinois Attorney General Kwame Raoul spokesperson Annie Thompson confirmed his office received the complaint but

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INSIDE

Europeans warn of Russian threat

Four years ago, U.S. officials in Munich warned of an imminent Russian invasion of Ukraine, and European officials dismissed it. Now the roles are largely reversed. **Nation & World**

Sox shortstop aims for consistency

Colson Montgomery arrived at previous spring training camps with the mindset of having something to prove. His thought process hasn’t changed despite a strong 2025. **Chicago Sports**

